

Necessitism and contingentism

PHIL UA-78 Metaphysics

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Qualitativeness and Extreme Anti-Essentialism

Another application of qualitativeness

Recall the following principle turned out to be inconsistent:

Extreme Anti-Essentialism (first pass) Every property that could be instantiated could be instantiated by any object.

Using the concept of qualitativeness, we can now state a consistent refinement that still entails (given standard views about what's qualitative) that any given object could be a poached egg, volcano, etc.:

Extreme Anti-Essentialism (second pass) Every **qualitative** property that could be instantiated could be instantiated by any object.

- Note that this conflicts radically with *Anti-Haecceitism*. (Why?)

Extreme Anti-Essentialism, continued

Extreme Anti-Essentialism (second pass) entails that NYU could be an egg, and that Columbia could be an egg. But it does not entail that NYU and Columbia could *both* be eggs. But surely, someone who liked the idea that the truth about de re modality is “boring” in this way would also be hostile to “interesting” principles about which qualitative roles objects can *simultaneously* occupy. So the vision seems to motivate a stronger claim:

Extreme Anti-Essentialism (third pass) For any natural number n : every n -ary qualitative relation that could be instantiated by n distinct objects could be instantiated by any n distinct objects.

Extreme Anti-Essentialism versus physicalist supervenience

Recall:

Democritean Supervenience All facts supervene with metaphysical necessity on the facts about what atoms there are, what shape each one is, and how far apart any two of them are at each time.

Suppose moreover that there is some *finite* number n of atoms, $a_1, \dots, a_n$.

Then Democritean Supervenience implies that there is an n -ary relation R such that the fact that $R(a_1, \dots, a_n)$ necessitates all facts, where R is of the form

being objects $x_1 \dots x_n$ such that $x_1 \dots x_n$ are all and only the atoms, and x_1 has shape S_1 , and... and x_n has shape S_n , and x_1 and x_2 have distance-history D_1 , and... and x_{n-1} and x_n have distance-history $D_{\frac{n(n-1)}{2}}$

This R seems to be qualitative.

Extreme Anti-Essentialism versus physicalist supervenience

But now consider any two objects b_1 and b_2 that are not atoms, where b_1 has some qualitative property Q that b_2 lacks.

Let R^+ be the following $n + 1$ -ary relation:

being objects $x_1, \dots, x_{n+1}$ such that $R(x_1, \dots, x_n)$ and $Q(x_{n+1})$.

R^+ is qualitative too, and instantiated by $a_1, \dots, a_n, b_1$.

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So Extreme Anti-Essentialism (third pass) entails that it's possible for R^+ to be instantiated by $a_1, \dots, a_n, b_2$.

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But Democritean Supervenience says that this is not possible: $R(a_1, \dots, a_n)$ necessitates all facts, including the fact that not $Q(b_2)$.

Extreme Anti-Essentialism versus physicalist supervenience

Of course, Democritean Supervenience itself isn't very plausible. But a similar issue will arise for a very wide range of claims of a similar sort, according to which there are some "basic" objects such that all the facts are necessitated by some collection of facts about their qualitative properties and relations.

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Although if there are *infinitely many* of these 'basic' objects, the argument becomes more complicated, and may require some further strengthening of Extreme Anti-Essentialism (third pass).

Necessitism and contingentism

Expressions like 'something', 'everything', 'nothing', 'most things', 'some dog', 'every dog', 'no dog', 'most dogs' are called *unary* (or 'singular' or 'monadic') quantifiers. Expressions like 'some', 'every', 'no', and 'most' are called *binary quantifiers*.

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'Quantifier' is also used for the *meanings* of such expressions.

Following Frege's *Begriffsschrift*, the standard view is that the meaning of a unary quantifier is a *property of properties*, while the meaning of a binary quantifier is a *binary relation among properties*.

Restricted versus unrestricted quantification

Many ordinary uses of quantifiers are *restricted*. 'Everything is in the fridge' could mean 'Everything I bought at the supermarket is in the fridge'. 'Most students passed' could mean 'Most students in my class passed'.

But there also seem to be *absolutely unrestricted* uses of quantifiers. A physicist who says 'Nothing travels faster than light' probably means that *absolutely nothing* does this. If I say 'Nothing in my fridge is worth more than \$20', I probably mean that *absolutely nothing* is both in my fridge and worth more than \$20.

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- FYI: some philosophers deny that it’s even possible to interpret quantifiers as absolutely unrestricted. This view is quite hard to make sense of, and I’m going to ignore it.

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$$\Box \forall x \Box \exists y (x = y)$$

NB: we mean *metaphysical* necessity and *unrestricted* quantification.

- The important ‘necessarily’ is the second one. The first one isn’t very interesting, since just about anyone who would accept the version without ‘necessarily’ would also accept the version with it.

Contingentism Possibly, something is, possibly, not identical to anything.

Possibly (for some object x (possibly (for every object y ($x \neq y$))))

$$\Diamond \exists x \Diamond \forall y (x \neq y)$$

By the duality of 'necessarily' and 'possibly' and the duality of 'every' and 'some', this is equivalent to the negation of necessitism.

- Again, the important 'possibly' is the second one.

Note that the truth of Necessitism on the intended interpretation of 'necessarily' as expressing metaphysical necessity implies its truth on all narrower interpretations of the modal. (And those who deny it also normally deny it for many narrower modalities.)

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By contrast, Necessitism is obviously false on many restricted readings of the quantifiers.

- E.g.: it is obviously *not* necessary that everything in my fridge is identical to something in my fridge, since the carton of milk in my fridge could have not been in the fridge, in which case it would also (by Leibniz's Law) not have been identical to anything in the fridge.